

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

SCHOOLS OF VEDANTA - Layered Premium Solved-Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

PHILOSOPHY PAPER I | INDIAN PHILOSOPHY 08

SCHOOLS OF VEDANTA

One textual inheritance, three architectures of reality

ADVAITA

DIFFERENCE AS
APPEARANCE

Recognition

VISISTADVAITA

DIFFERENCE AS
QUALIFICATION

Communion

DVAITA

DIFFERENCE AS
ULTIMATE FACT

Service

Brahman | Isvara | Atman | Jiva | Jagat | Maya | Moksa

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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SOLVED PYQ BANK - ALL 20 VERIFIED VEDANTA QUESTIONS

The wording, year and marks are taken from the continuous local Paper I bank for 2018-2025. There are exactly 20 primary-owned Vedanta question-parts.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: What is the difference between the indescribability (Anirvacanīyatā) of Brahman and the indescribability (Anirvacanīyatā) of Māyā in the Advaita Vedānta system? Discuss.

Model solution

Advaita uses **anirvacaniyata** in two importantly different senses. Brahman is indescribable because it is non-dual, non-objectifiable reality; Maya is indescribable because its ontological status cannot be fixed as either ultimately real or absolutely unreal.

Brahman. The *Bṛhadaranyaka Upaniṣad* method of **neti neti** denies every limiting predicate. This does not make Brahman a blank non-being. **Sat-cit-ananda** expresses its intrinsic nature, while ordinary predicates fail because they place an object within a subject-predicate relation. Brahman's indescribability is therefore **transcategorical fullness**: it is the self-luminous ground of every act of description.

Maya. Maya is experienced through the world and illusion, so it is not **asat** like a hare's horn. Yet Brahman-knowledge sublates it, so it is not **sat**, which Advaita defines as never sublated. Rope-snake and shell-silver show this intermediate, dependent status. Maya's indescribability is therefore **ontological indefiniteness under sublation**, not transcendence as ultimate reality.

Brahman	Maya
never sublated	sublated by knowledge
self-established reality	dependent appearance-power
beyond predicates because non-objective	neither sat nor asat
liberating truth	condition of bondage

Thus the same word must not conceal opposite functions: Brahman is indescribable because it exceeds finite predication; Maya because it fails to qualify as ultimate being or sheer non-being.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact distinction, uses *neti neti*, sat-cit-ananda and rope-snake as named evidence, and prevents the common error of placing Brahman and Maya in one ontological class.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: Give a comparative exposition of the concept of Mokṣa as found in the systems of Viśiṣṭādvaita, Dvaita, Śuddhādvaita and Acintyabhedābheda.

Model solution

The four schools agree that mokṣa is release from bondage through a God-centred transformation, but they differ because they assign different final relations among Brahman, self and world.

Visistadvaita

For **Ramanuja**, the jiva is a real atomic mode of Narayana, inseparable through **aprthaksiddhi** but never identical. Bhakti, culminating in **prapatti** and divine grace, removes karmic obstruction. Moksa is perfected knowledge, bliss and eternal service. The body-soul model proves that dependence can be total without destroying personal identity.

Dvaita

For **Madhva**, Visnu alone is independent and the five differences are eternal. Right knowledge, devotion and grace liberate, but the self never becomes God. **Taratamya** means liberated souls need not possess identical bliss. This preserves devotion most strongly, though it makes hierarchy metaphysically permanent.

Suddhadvaita

For **Vallabha**, Brahman as Krsna is pure non-dual reality and the world is a real manifestation, not a Maya-produced illusion. The soul is a real expression of Brahman whose bliss is obscured. Grace-oriented devotion, especially the **pusti** path, restores participation in divine bliss without the Advaita claim that the experienced world is mithya.

Acintyabhedabheda

For the Caitanya tradition, jiva and world are simultaneously different and non-different from Krsna through divine powers; the relation is **acintya**, beyond complete conceptual capture. Loving devotion is both means and end. Liberation is not featureless absorption but fulfilled loving relation.

School	Final self-God relation	Main means	Distinctive result
Visistadvaita	inseparable mode, non-identical	bhakti/prapatti/grace	communion and service
Dvaita	eternal difference	bhakti/right knowledge/grace	service with taratamya
Suddhadvaita	real manifestation/participation	grace and devotion	divine bliss
Acintyabhedabheda	inconceivable difference-non-difference	loving devotion	eternal relational love

The common devotional vocabulary should not hide the metaphysical gradient: qualified unity, strict difference, pure real manifestation and inconceivable dual-nondual relation generate four distinct accounts of freedom.

Why this earns marks: It covers every named school, links ontology to means and final state, uses school-specific terminology, and ends with a comparative rather than generic bhakti conclusion.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2018 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: How does Rāmānuja refute the doctrine of Māyā as propounded by Śaṅkara? Why is Māyā needed by both Rāmānuja and Śaṅkara to establish their doctrines? Discuss.

☐ **Printed wording:** the philosophically unusual second sentence is printed this way and is retained.

Model solution

The first demand is philosophically clear: Ramanuja refutes Sankara's Maya through the **sapta-anupapatti**, the seven alleged incoherences of Advaita's avidya doctrine. The second printed demand is unusual because Ramanuja does **not** require Maya in Sankara's anirvacaniya sense. It should be answered by distinguishing their rival explanations of plurality.

Ramanuja asks where avidya resides (**asraya**): in Brahman it compromises pure consciousness; in jiva it is circular because jiva is itself explained through avidya. **Tirodhana** objects that self-luminous Brahman cannot be concealed. **Svarupa** and **anirvacaniyatva** object that neither-real-nor-unreal is incoherent. **Pramana** asks how positive avidya is known. **Nivartaka** and **nivrtti** question what knowledge removes avidya and how an entity of uncertain status can cease.

Advaita replies that ignorance is beginningless, witnessed in "I do not know," inferable from bondage, and sublated by mahavakya-generated knowledge. Cloud-cover explains apparent concealment; rope-snake explains cessation without a new entity being produced. Yet the locus and proof objections retain force because Bhamati and Vivarana give different answers.

Why, then, is Maya "needed"? **Sankara** needs Maya as the dependent principle that reconciles changeless Brahman with experienced plurality through **vivarta**. **Ramanuja rejects that need**. He explains plurality through real **cit** and **acit**, inseparable from Brahman by **aprthaksiddhi**, and through the **sarira-sariri** relation. If the printed line is read charitably, both systems need an account of the one-many relation, but only Sankara calls that explanatory principle Maya.

Thus Ramanuja's critique is constructive, not merely negative: real qualified unity replaces indescribable appearance.

Why this earns marks: It respects the exact printed anomaly, lists and groups the seven objections, presents Advaita replies, and clearly states that Ramanuja does not accept Advaitic Maya.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: Explain the logical consequences of the metaphysical absolutism of Advaitism.

Model solution

Advaita's metaphysical absolutism holds that **Brahman alone is paramarthically real**. The logical consequences follow systematically across world, self, ethics, God and knowledge.

First, the world cannot possess independent ultimate reality. It becomes **mithya**—experienced and causally effective at the vyavaharika level, yet sublated by Brahman-knowledge. Rope-snake supplies the model: appearance depends on a real substrate without modifying it.

Second, finite individuality and agency become provisional. The jiva as doer and enjoyer arises through avidya and adhyasa; **atman is Brahman**. This supports liberation by knowledge but generates the objection that bondage of the ever-free self is difficult to explain.

Third, ethics, karma and duty remain binding only within vyavahara. Sankara can preserve moral discipline through **sadhana-catustaya**, but critics argue that ultimate sublation weakens moral realism. The reply is level-sensitive: one cannot invoke ultimate truth to evade empirical obligations while ignorance persists.

Fourth, personal God is relativised. Isvara, Brahman conditioned by Maya, is omniscient creator and moral governor within cosmic experience, but nirguna Brahman alone is final. Ramanuja objects that this makes bhakti and scriptural theism preparatory.

Fifth, all pramanas—including sruti—operate through knower-known duality and are finally transcended. Advaita answers the self-reference charge through the ladder or clearing-nut model: scripture removes ignorance and then loses operative relevance.

Finally, moksha must be recognition, not production: **praptasya praptih**. Jivanmukti becomes possible because knowledge, not a future event, destroys bondage.

Advaita therefore gains unmatched unity and an elegant theory of liberation, but at the cost of grading world, agency, devotion and even its own means of proof as lower truth. Its coherence depends on accepting **badha** as the criterion of levels of reality.

Why this earns marks: It derives six consequences from the thesis, connects each to named Advaita doctrines and rival objections, and gives a conditional rather than celebratory verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Point out the significance of the five-fold differences in the Dualistic School of Vedānta.

Model solution

Madhva's **pancavidhabheda** states that five differences are real and eternal: (1) jiva-Isvara, (2) jiva-jiva, (3) jiva-jada, (4) Isvara-jada and (5) jada-jada.

Its first significance is **ontological**. Difference is not produced by avidya and cannot be sublated by knowledge. This directly rejects Sankara's claim that plurality is only vyavaharically real.

Second, it is **epistemological**. Knowledge requires a real knower, known object and distinction between them. By treating difference as intrinsic, Madhva explains why ordinary and scriptural cognition need not be demoted to a lower truth.

Third, it is **theological**. Jiva-Isvara difference secures Visnu's independence (**svatantra**) and the soul's complete dependence (**paratantra**). Devotion remains a permanent relation rather than a provisional step toward identity.

Fourth, it is **soteriological**. Moksa is eternal service, not merger. Jiva-jiva difference also makes **taratamya**, gradation among liberated souls, possible.

Finally, jada-jada and jiva-jada differences give the world robust reality. Matter is neither Brahman nor illusion.

The doctrine's strength is clarity about relation and plurality; its cost is a metaphysical pluralism and hierarchy that Advaita regards as incompatible with an absolute. Nevertheless, the five differences form one integrated anti-Advaita system, not a mere list.

Why this earns marks: It names all five differences and explains their ontological, epistemological, theological and soteriological work instead of stopping at enumeration.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2020 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: Discuss the nature and types of matter according to Nimbārka.

Model solution

Nimbarka's **Dvaitadvaita** accepts Brahman, conscious selves (**cit**) and non-conscious reality (**acit**) as real. Matter is neither illusion nor an independent absolute: it is different from Brahman yet non-different through complete dependence.

Standard expositions classify acit into three forms:

1. **Prakṛta**: primordial material nature and its transformations, constituting the empirical cosmos and bodies.
2. **Aprakṛta**: non-prakṛtic substance associated with the divine realm and divine embodiment; it is not produced from ordinary prakṛti.
3. **Kala**: time, the condition of succession and transformation. Its exact placement varies in summaries, so the adopted classification should be stated rather than embellished.

The philosophical point of the classification is relational. Prakṛta matter changes; aprakṛta reality secures a divine order not reducible to empirical matter; kala explains temporal process. Yet none exists independently of Brahman. The relation is often understood through power and possessor of power: dependence yields non-difference, while distinct attributes and functions yield difference.

This differs from Sankara, for whom the world is mithya under vivarta, and from Madhva, for whom difference is eternally ultimate. Nimbarka preserves a real world and real selves while refusing complete separation from their ground.

Thus matter in Dvaitadvaita is real, differentiated, transformable and Brahman-dependent. The threefold account supports a metaphysics in which difference and non-difference are equally basic aspects of one relation.

Why this earns marks: It gives the three required types, explains their functions, and connects the classification to Nimbarka's central doctrine rather than presenting isolated labels.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2020 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Discuss the nature and relationship of Jīva and Jīva-sākṣī according to non-dualism.

Model solution

In Advaita, **jīva** and **jīva-sakṣi** are not two ultimately separate selves. They are two standpoints on one consciousness: jīva is consciousness appearing as the embodied knower through avidya and the inner organ; sakṣi is the unaffected witness that illumines those changing states.

The jīva says "I know, act, enjoy and suffer." These predicates belong to body, senses and antahkarana through **adhyasa**. Advaita explains the appearance through **avacchedavada**—one space seeming divided by pots—or **pratibimbavada**—one face reflected differently in mirrors. Both models preserve the original consciousness from real division.

The **sakṣi** is self-luminous and non-objectifiable. It witnesses waking, dream and deep sleep, as well as pleasure, doubt and memory, without becoming any of them. The continuity recognised across states points to a witness distinct

from each mental modification.

Their relation is therefore apparent conditioning, not substance-to-substance connection. Jiva is saksi identified with upadhis; saksi is the same consciousness considered free of those identifications. When mahavakya-generated knowledge removes avidya, no jiva travels to or merges with another entity. The false limitation is sublated.

A critic may ask how an unreal limitation produces real bondage. Advaita replies that bondage is empirically effective like fear generated by a rope-snake, though cancelled by knowledge. The answer succeeds if levels of reality are accepted; realist schools regard the upadhi explanation as insufficient.

Why this earns marks: It defines both terms, gives two internal Advaita models, explains liberation, and avoids the central error of treating jiva and saksi as two ultimate consciousnesses.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2021 Q7(a), 20 marks

Question: How do the advocates of anirvacanīya-khyāti refute the position of the Naiyāyikas and establish the position of Advaitins regarding the problem of error? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Anirvacaniya-khyati explains error by holding that the illusory object is presented but cannot be classified as ultimately real or absolutely unreal. Advaita uses this to reject Nyaya's **anyatha-khyati**.

Nyaya argues that shell-silver illusion presents a real silver known elsewhere in the wrong locus, aided by extraordinary cognition and similarity. The shell is perceived as "this"; remembered real silver supplies "silver"; error is mislocation, not creation of a third ontological object.

Advaita raises three objections. First, the subject experiences silver **here**, not merely a memory of silver elsewhere. Second, correction—"this is shell"—cancels the silver at the locus rather than relocating it. Third, if the presented silver were fully real, it should not be destroyed by knowledge of the substrate.

Advaita's positive account begins with **avidya**. Defective conditions conceal the shell and project silver. The silver is not **sat**, because it is sublated; not **asat**, because it appears. It is therefore **anirvacaniya**. The criterion is **badha**: never-sublated Brahman is paramarthika, the common world is vyavaharika, and shell-silver is pratibhasika.

The theory has wider metaphysical significance: what illusory silver is to shell, jagat is to Brahman. Error theory becomes a model for vivartavada.

Critically, Nyaya can object that "neither real nor unreal" invents a third category without independent proof. Advaita replies that the categories concern grades of sublatability, not a bare violation of excluded middle. The reply is persuasive within Advaita's level-ontology but not compulsory for a realist who rejects badha as the measure of being.

Why this earns marks: It states Nyaya fairly, gives Advaita's refutation and positive account, links error to metaphysics, and retains the realist objection in the verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2021 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question: Compare and contrast the views of Śaṅkara and Rāmānuja regarding the status of the world.

Model solution

Sankara and Ramanuja agree that the world depends on Brahman and is not an autonomous second absolute. They disagree over whether that dependence permits the world to be ultimately real.

For **Sankara**, Brahman is changeless nirguna reality. A real transformation would compromise absoluteness; hence creation is **vivarta**, apparent transformation. The world is **mithya**: empirically valid but sublatale, like snake on rope. Isvara, jivas and causal order belong to vyavahara, while Brahman alone is paramarthika.

For **Ramanuja**, the world is real **acit**, an inseparable mode of saguna Brahman. Through **aparthaksiddhi** and the **sarira-sariri** model, the universe is God's body: supported, controlled and existing for the indwelling Lord. Creation is a real manifestation through Brahman's modes, not an illusion.

Dimension	Sankara	Ramanuja
world	mithya	real

Dimension	Sankara	Ramanuja
causation	vivarta	real manifestation
God-world relation	empirical conditioning	intrinsic body-soul relation
liberation	sublation of world-difference	perfected communion within real relation

Sankara's evidence is the Upanisadic insistence on non-duality and the impossibility of change in the absolute. Ramanuja cites the same scriptures as describing a qualified, purposive source and argues that negations remove defects, not all qualities.

Sankara protects immutability by lowering world-status; Ramanuja protects world, devotion and scripture by qualifying unity. The stronger view depends on whether absoluteness requires absence of real internal differentiation.

Why this earns marks: It compares the same dimensions, names each causal model and analogy, and ends with the precise presupposition separating the schools.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2021 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain the status of jīva and jagat in the philosophy of Madhvācārya.

Model solution

Madhva's Dvaita treats both **jīva** and **jagat** as real, dependent and eternally distinct from Visnu. Neither is a product of ignorance, and liberation does not abolish their difference.

The jīva is a conscious, finite, dependent substance. Visnu alone is **svatantra**; every soul is **paratantra**. Jīva-Isvara difference is one of the five real differences, while jīva-jīva difference explains genuine plurality among selves. This secures responsibility, devotion and the permanent subject of liberation.

Jagat is also real. Matter is distinct from God and soul, and material things differ from one another. The jīva-jada, Isvara-jada and jada-jada differences prevent the world from being reduced either to divine identity or Advaitic appearance. Dependence on God means governance and ontological support, not numerical sameness.

The **pancavidhabheda** system joins the two doctrines: soul-God, soul-soul, soul-matter, God-matter and matter-matter differences are eternal. Consequently, knowledge reveals difference rather than subsuming it. Moksha is grace-enabled loving service; it preserves selfhood and may include **taratamya** among liberated souls.

Compared with Ramanuja, Madhva rejects even the qualified non-dual claim that selves and world form God's body as inseparable modes. Compared with Sankara, he rejects mithyatva entirely.

The account offers strong realism and religious relation, but its price is ultimate plurality and a contested hierarchy of souls. For Madhva, however, plurality is not an imperfection; it is the ordered reality sustained by Visnu.

Why this earns marks: It explains jīva and jagat together through dependence and all five differences, then derives epistemic and soteriological consequences.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2022 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: Do you agree with the view that 'Vivartavāda is the logical development of Parīṇāmavāda'? Give reasons in support of your answer.

Model solution

Vivartavāda may be called the logical development of parīṇāmavāda only in a **qualified** sense. It inherits causal dependence but transforms the meaning of effect.

Parīṇāmavāda, classically represented by Sāṃkhya, holds that the effect is a real transformation of a pre-existing cause. Milk becomes curd; prakṛti evolves into the tattvas. The cause genuinely changes form.

Advaita accepts the satkāryavāda insight that an effect cannot arise from sheer nothing and that the world must depend on a ground. Yet Brahman is changeless, partless and absolute. If Brahman really became the world, it would acquire modification and plurality. Hence Sankara converts real transformation into **vivarta**: the effect appears on the cause without altering it, as snake appears on rope.

Vivarta is therefore a "development" because it radicalises the demand that the effect be non-independent of its cause. But it is also a break because it denies the equal reality and real modification affirmed by parinama.

Ramanuja exposes the cost: if the effect is only mithya, scripture, devotion and world-process become lower truth. Sankara replies that empirical validity is preserved until Brahman-knowledge; mithya is not tuccha.

My judgement is conditional. Vivartavada is a logical refinement of causal dependence under the premise of an immutable absolute, but not a straightforward continuation of Samkhya's realist transformation.

Why this earns marks: It defines both theories, uses milk-curd and rope-snake, identifies continuity and rupture, and directly answers "Do you agree?" with a qualified verdict.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2022 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: 'Brahma satyam jaganmithyā, Jīva Brahmaiva nāparaḥ'. In the light of this statement explain the ontological status of Īśvara, Jīva and Sākṣī as elucidated in Advaita Vedānta.

Model solution

The formula "**Brahma satyam jagan mithya, jivo brahmaiva naparah**" states Advaita's hierarchy: Brahman alone is ultimate, the world is dependent appearance, and the jiva is not other than Brahman. Isvara, jiva and saksi must therefore be located carefully.

Isvara is Brahman conditioned by or reflected in **Maya**. He is omniscient, creator, giver of karmic fruits and the object of devotion. This is not pratibhasika illusion: Isvara is fully authoritative at the **vyavaharika** level. Yet creatorhood and omniscience are relational predicates, so nirguna Brahman transcends them at the paramarthika level.

Jiva is the same consciousness conditioned by **avidya**, body and antahkarana. Avacchedavada compares it to pot-space; pratibimbavada to a face reflected in a limited mirror. Agency, enjoyment and bondage are empirically effective but do not divide Brahman.

Saksi is pure witness-consciousness, illuminating all mental states without change. It is immediate and non-objectifiable. Unlike jiva, it is not essentially doer or enjoyer; those predicates arise through adhyasa.

Brahman

- | Maya standpoint -> Isvara, cosmic knower
- | avidya standpoint -> jiva, finite knower
- | free of identification -> saksi, witness

The distinctions are pedagogical and empirical, not three ultimate substances. Mahavakya knowledge removes the jiva's limiting identification; Isvara-jiva difference is also transcended in Brahman.

Ramanuja objects that this makes God and devotion provisional. Advaita replies that empirical authority is not falsity and remains binding until knowledge. The scheme is coherent if levels of reality are accepted; otherwise it appears to derive theology from an ultimately sublated distinction.

Why this earns marks: It explains all three statuses, uses two Advaita models and the level-ontology, and addresses the theological objection rather than merely repeating the formula.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2022 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: How does the concept of Liberation (Mokṣa) of Madhvācārya differ from that of Rāmānujācārya? Explain.

Model solution

Madhva and Ramanuja both reject Advaitic identity and make devotion and grace central, yet their concepts of moksa differ because Dvaita affirms eternal difference while Visistadvaita affirms inseparable qualified unity.

For **Ramanuja**, the jiva is a real atomic mode of Brahman through **aparthaksiddhi**. Bhakti, prapatti and God's grace remove karmic bondage. The liberated self retains individuality and enjoys direct knowledge, bliss and eternal service of Narayana. The body-soul model makes the self wholly dependent but internal to one qualified Brahman.

For **Madhva**, the jiva is a real dependent substance eternally distinct from Visnu and from other jivas. Moksa comes through right knowledge of difference, devotion and grace. It is blissful service, never identity or inclusion as a mode.

Taratamya means liberated souls may enjoy different degrees of bliss.

Issue	Ramanuja	Madhva
ontology	qualified non-duality	dualism/plural realism
self-God relation	inseparable mode/body	eternal difference
liberating knowledge	dependence within unity	fivefold difference and supremacy of Visnu
final state	communion and service	service with taratamya

Both reject strict Advaita jivanmukti: liberation is not simply discovering that individuality was unreal. Yet Ramanuja integrates plurality within one divine whole, whereas Madhva refuses all identity.

Thus the difference is not bhakti versus bhakti, but communion within qualified unity versus fulfilment of eternal duality.

Why this earns marks: It establishes common ground, compares ontology, means and final condition, and highlights taratamya and aprthaksiddhi as decisive evidence.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2023 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: What is Advaitin interpretation of the great sentence (mahāvākya) 'Thou art that' (tat tvam asi)? Briefly discuss.

Model solution

Advaita interprets **tat tvam asi** through **bhaga-tyaga-laksana** or jahad-ajahal-laksana, because the direct meanings of "that" and "thou" appear contradictory.

The **vac्यartha** of *tat* is Isvara—omniscient, cosmic cause and Lord, associated with Maya. The direct meaning of *tvam* is the finite jiva—embodied, ignorant and agentive, associated with avidya. These empirical predicates cannot be literally identical.

Advaita therefore abandons the incompatible adjuncts and retains the common **lakṣyārtha**, pure consciousness. The classic illustration is **"this is that Devadatta."** Differences of place, time and condition are dropped while the identical person is retained. Similarly, lordship and finitude are dropped; consciousness is recognised as one.

The sentence does not cause a new union. It removes avidya and reveals an identity always true: atman is Brahman. This is why mahavakya knowledge can liberate.

Ramanuja and Madhva reject this semantic reduction. They interpret Upanisadic unity through dependence, qualification or relation rather than numerical identity. Thus the reading of one sentence presupposes the entire Advaita ontology.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes direct and implied meanings, explains the precise semantic device, uses the Devadatta example and prevents crude identity between empirical jiva and Isvara.

Solved PYQ 15 - 2023 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: Discuss Rāmānuja's criticism of Śaṅkara's conception of Brahman and Īśvara (God).

Model solution

Ramanuja criticises Sankara's distinction between nirguna Brahman as ultimate and Isvara as Brahman conditioned by Maya. His objections are epistemological, scriptural, causal and religious.

First, **all cognition is of the qualified**. Ramanuja accepts a first, nirvikalpaka cognition, but not cognition of a wholly qualifierless object. A nirvisesa Brahman therefore cannot become a known referent. Advaita replies that Brahman is not an object of perception; sruti reveals it as self-luminous consciousness.

Second, Ramanuja reads scriptural negation as denial of defects, not denial of all qualities. Upanisadic predicates of knowledge, bliss, lordship and causality disclose **ananta-kalyana-gunas**. Sankara's nirguna reading, he argues, turns fullness into abstraction.

Third, an indeterminate Brahman cannot intelligibly cause a structured world. If Isvara alone creates but belongs only to vyavahara, ultimate reality is disconnected from cosmology. Ramanuja instead makes Narayana both efficient and

material cause through real cit and acit modes.

Fourth, Maya is incoherent. The **sapta-anupapatti** challenges its locus, concealment, nature, indefinability, proof, remover and cessation. Especially strong are the asraya dilemma and the absence of an independent pramana for positive avidya.

Fifth, reducing Isvara to lower truth weakens bhakti. Scriptural devotion appears merely preparatory to an impersonal realisation. Ramanuja's body-soul model makes God simultaneously immanent, transcendent and ultimately personal.

Advaita responds that qualities introduce relational limitation, whereas nirguna means free from limiting predicates, not blankness. Isvara remains empirically real and indispensable. The debate turns on whether absoluteness is best preserved by excluding real differentiation or by including it as inseparable qualification.

Ramanuja's critique is strongest in exposing the religious and causal costs of lower-status Isvara; Advaita remains strongest in protecting immutability and non-duality.

Why this earns marks: It covers all dimensions of the criticism, includes Advaita replies and Ramanuja's positive alternative, and gives a balanced graded conclusion.

Solved PYQ 16 - 2023 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Liberation is defined by Advaita Vedāntins as 'attainment of that which is already attained'. How does Śāṅkara illustrate this statement? Discuss with your own comments.

Model solution

Advaita defines moksha as **praptasya praptih**, attainment of what is already attained, because the self has never truly ceased to be Brahman. Bondage is avidya, not a real transformation or distance.

Sankara's standard illustration is the **necklace already on one's neck**. A person searches everywhere for a lost necklace until another points out that it is already worn. No new necklace is produced and no journey obtains it; knowledge removes the mistaken non-possession. Similarly, mahavakya knowledge removes the belief "I am a finite body-mind" and reveals atman-Brahman identity.

The rope-snake makes the negative side clear. Correct knowledge does not destroy a real snake; it sublates a projected one. Moksha therefore cannot be a karmic effect, because every produced effect is temporary. **Jnana alone** directly liberates; karma and upasana prepare the mind through sadhana-catustaya.

Jivanmukti follows logically. Knowledge can dawn while the body continues through **prarabdha karma**, like an arrow already released. Videhamukti adds no new essential freedom.

My comment is that the doctrine offers a powerful account of freedom as de-identification rather than acquisition. It avoids making the eternal dependent on a temporal event. Yet it inherits the problem of explaining how beginningless bondage can appear in self-luminous Brahman. Saying "avidya" is adequate only if adhyasa and levels of reality are independently defensible.

Thus liberation is attainment only from the ignorant standpoint; from the highest standpoint it is recognition that non-attainment never occurred.

Why this earns marks: It explains the paradox with necklace, rope-snake and arrow examples, derives jnana and jivanmukti, and adds a reasoned critical comment as demanded.

Solved PYQ 17 - 2024 Q5(e), 10 marks

Question: "In Viśiṣṭādvaita philosophy, the relationship between God and the world is parallel to that between an individual self and its body." Critically discuss.

Model solution

In Viśiṣṭādvaita, the God-world relation parallels the relation between an individual self and its body through **sarira-sariri-bhava**. The analogy expresses dependence and control, not a claim that the physical universe is God's gross body in an ordinary sense.

For Ramanuja, something is a body when it is (1) completely supported by a self, (2) controlled by that self, and (3) exists for that self's purposes. Cit and acit satisfy these marks in relation to Narayana. God is their indwelling ruler;

world and selves are real modes or **prakara**.

The analogy establishes immanence: nothing lies outside Brahman's sustaining presence. It also preserves transcendence: the indwelling self exceeds and controls the body. Through **aprthaksiddhi**, the world is inseparable but not numerically identical.

Its strength is that it preserves a real world, meaningful devotion and Brahman as both efficient and material cause without Advaitic mithyatva. Its limitation is the problem of defect: if the world is God's body, do suffering and change qualify God? Ramanuja replies that the controller is not reduced to the body's limitations; dependence does not transfer every defect to the indwelling self.

The parallel is therefore philosophically illuminating but analogical, not complete identity. It secures qualified unity: plurality is real yet internal to one divine whole.

Why this earns marks: It states the three technical marks of bodyhood, connects them to aprthaksiddhi and causation, and critically tests rather than merely repeats the analogy.

Solved PYQ 18 - 2025 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Examine Rāmānuja's seven objections against Māyāvāda of Advaita.

Model solution

Ramanuja's **sapta-anupapatti** presents seven objections to Advaita's Maya/avidya:

1. **Asraya:** avidya cannot reside in Brahman without tainting it, or in jiva without circularity.
2. **Tirodhana:** self-luminous Brahman cannot be concealed.
3. **Svarupa:** the nature of avidya is incoherent.
4. **Anirvacaniyatva:** neither real nor unreal appears to violate exhaustive classification.
5. **Pramana:** no valid means establishes positive avidya.
6. **Nivartaka:** it is unclear what cognition can remove avidya.
7. **Nivrtti:** if avidya is real it cannot cease; if unreal there is nothing to remove.

Advaita replies that avidya is beginningless but sublata; concealment is relative to the jiva like cloud-cover to a viewer; "I do not know," arthapatti and sruti establish ignorance; and mahavakya-generated knowledge cancels it as rope-knowledge cancels the snake.

The objections target one system at three levels: the **locus**, the **nature/proof**, and the **removal** of avidya. Ramanuja's constructive alternative is real cit and acit inseparable from Brahman through aprthaksiddhi.

The asraya and pramana objections remain strongest because Advaita sub-schools differ over the locus and because witness-awareness may be read as mere absence of knowledge.

Why this earns marks: It names all seven, groups their philosophical purpose, gives concise Advaita replies and identifies the strongest residual difficulties.

Solved PYQ 19 - 2025 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: How is Brahman conceptualised in Advaita philosophy as both Nimitta and Upādāna Kāraṇa of the World? Discuss with suitable examples.

Model solution

Advaita conceptualises Brahman as both **nimitta-karana**, the intelligent efficient cause, and **upadana-karana**, the material basis of the world, because no independent second reality can supply either intelligence or material.

As efficient cause, Brahman under the empirical standpoint is Isvara—omniscient, purposive creator and dispenser of karmic fruits. The *Taittiriya* formula that beings arise from, live by and return to the ultimate, and the *Brahma-sutra* opening inquiry into the source of world-order support this role.

As material cause, Brahman must underlie every name and form. The **spider and web** image is decisive: the web issues from the spider rather than from alien material. Clay-pot and gold-ornament analogies show the effect's dependence on a common substrate.

Yet Advaita qualifies material causation through **vivartavada**. Brahman does not really transform as milk becomes curd. The world appears on Brahman as snake on rope. Therefore Brahman is the basis of the effect without undergoing modification; Maya supplies name-form at the vyavaharika level.

This differs from Samkhya, where unconscious prakrti is material cause and no creator is required, and from Nyaya, where God is efficient cause while eternal atoms are material causes. Advaita reunites both causal functions in one ground.

Ramanuja accepts Brahman as both causes but rejects vivarta: cit and acit are real modes and creation is real manifestation. His objection is that apparent material causation risks making the world and divine purpose lower truth. Advaita replies that empirical causality remains valid while the absolute stays changeless.

Thus Brahman is both causes, but not in the ordinary transformative sense: intelligent Isvara orders the cosmos, while immutable Brahman is the non-dual substrate of its appearance.

Why this earns marks: It defines both causes, gives three named analogies, distinguishes vivarta from transformation, and compares Samkhya, Nyaya and Ramanuja.

Solved PYQ 20 - 2025 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: Discuss the idea of Bimba-pratibimbavāda as presented in Vedānta philosophy along with its soteriological significance.

Model solution

Bimba-pratibimbavada is an Advaita model in which one consciousness appears as original and reflection without undergoing real division. It explains the Isvara-jiva relation and points toward liberation.

The **bimba** is original consciousness. Reflected in the pure cosmic medium of **Maya**, it is Isvara—omniscient and the regulator of the empirical world. Reflected in individual **avidya** or antahkarana, it appears as finite jiva. As one face seems many in differently conditioned mirrors, consciousness appears plural while the original remains unaffected.

The model explains several facts. Dependence is secured because a reflection has no autonomy from its original. Individual variation is explained by differences in reflecting media. Brahman's purity is preserved because a dirty mirror distorts the image, not the face.

It differs from **avacchedavada**, which emphasises limitation like pot-space, and **abhasavada**, which stresses semblance. All agree that individuality is not an ultimate fragmentation of Brahman.

Its soteriological significance is central. Bondage belongs to identification with the reflected, limited standpoint. When avidya is removed by mahavakya knowledge, the jiva recognises that its consciousness was never independent of the original. The reflection does not travel, merge or become newly real; false autonomy is sublated. This supports **praptasya praptih** and jivanmukti.

Ramanuja and Madhva object that the reflection model turns real personhood and devotion into provisional appearance. A further problem is whether unconscious avidya can literally reflect consciousness. Advaita treats the analogy as explanatory rather than physical: it expresses appearance, dependence and non-affection.

The model is therefore strongest as a soteriological grammar of de-identification, not as a literal optical theory. It connects one consciousness, empirical plurality and liberation without positing real division.

Why this earns marks: It defines both terms and media, compares internal Advaita models, derives four explanatory functions and gives a critical soteriological verdict.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - 32 QUESTIONS

Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D, repeated eight times. MCQs 25-32 are explicit remedial items targeting recurrent Vedanta errors.

MCQ 1

Which formulation correctly distinguishes Brahman's two standard marks?

A. Svarupa: sat-cit-ananda; tatastha: source, sustenance and dissolution of the world B. Svarupa: creatorhood; tatastha: absence of qualities C. Svarupa: five differences; tatastha: body-soul relation D. Svarupa: Maya; tatastha: avidya

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Svarupa-laksana states intrinsic nature; tatastha-laksana indicates Brahman through world-causality.

MCQ 2

Why is sabda primary for Brahman in Advaita?

A. Because perception is always false B. Because Brahman is non-objectifiable and cannot be reached as an ordinary sensory or inferential object C. Because inference is rejected in all empirical matters D. Because only spoken testimony is valid

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Advaita accepts perception and inference empirically, but sruti uniquely reveals non-objective Brahman.

MCQ 3

Ramanuja's main epistemic objection to nirguna Brahman is that

A. only inference can know Brahman B. qualities belong only to matter C. all cognition is of a qualified object, so a wholly qualifierless Brahman cannot be known D. scripture never uses negation

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Ramanuja reinterprets first cognition but denies cognition of a wholly nirvisesa object.

MCQ 4

In Madhva's metaphysics, the most basic classification is

A. sat and asat B. cit and acit as Brahman's body C. paramarthika and vyavaharika D. Visnu as svatantra and all else as paratantra

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Dvaita grounds its theism in the sole independence of Visnu and dependence of souls and matter.

MCQ 5

In pratibimbavada, defects in the reflecting medium affect

A. the reflected appearance, not original consciousness B. Brahman itself C. only Isvara, never jiva D. the validity of all scripture

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The mirror analogy protects the bimba from the limitations visible in the pratibimba.

MCQ 6

Which statement best distinguishes jiva and saksi in Advaita?

A. They are two eternal substances B. Jiva is consciousness identified with limiting adjuncts; saksi is the unaffected witness C. Saksi is created by jiva D. Jiva is real while saksi is illusory

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The distinction is standpoint-based, not a duality of ultimate selves.

MCQ 7

Dharma-bhuta-jnana helps Ramanuja explain

A. how Maya projects the world B. why all selves are identical C. how an atomic self can have cognition extending beyond its atomic size D. why matter is unreal

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The self is anu, while its attributive consciousness can expand when karmic obstruction is removed.

MCQ 8

Which model emphasises delimitation rather than reflection?

A. Satkhyati B. Abhasavada C. Anirvacaniya-khyati D. Avacchedavada

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Pot-space is the standard image of apparent limitation in avacchedavada.

MCQ 9

Jagat is mithya in Advaita because it is

A. experienced but sublatale, neither absolutely real nor sheer non-being B. never experienced C. identical with tuccha D. an independent material cause

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Mithya preserves empirical presentation while denying never-sublated reality.

MCQ 10

Vivartavada differs from parinamavada because vivarta

A. denies causal dependence B. denies real transformation of the cause C. accepts creation from nothing D. makes matter independent of Brahman

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The effect depends on Brahman without Brahman changing as milk changes into curd.

MCQ 11

Ramanuja's body-soul analogy primarily establishes that the world is

A. a dream of the jiva B. independent of God C. supported, controlled and purposive as a real mode of God D. identical with God's every attribute

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The three marks of bodyhood ground real dependence without numerical identity.

MCQ 12

Which is NOT one of Advaita's three levels of reality?

A. Paramarthika B. Vyavaharika C. Pratibhasika D. Paratantrika

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Paratantra is a dependence category, especially important in Dvaita, not one of Advaita's three levels.

MCQ 13

Avarana-sakti refers to

A. concealment of the substrate's true nature B. projection of names and forms C. real transformation of prakrti D. eternal difference among souls

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Avarana conceals; viksepa projects.

MCQ 14

The asraya-anupapatti asks

A. whether Brahman has qualities B. where avidya can reside without impurity or circularity C. whether moksa is blissful D. whether the Veda is authorless

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Brahman as locus risks impurity; jiva as locus risks mutual dependence.

MCQ 15

Adhyasa is best defined as

A. absence of all cognition B. real production of the world C. mutual superimposition of self and not-self D. eternal difference between God and soul

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Sankara's *atasmin tad-buddhih* captures taking one thing for another.

MCQ 16

The strongest safe formulation of the Maya-avidya relation is

A. they are always wholly unrelated B. Ramanuja accepts both as anirvacaniya C. Maya is real and avidya unreal D. usage varies; often Maya is cosmic and avidya individual

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Advaita sources vary, so qualified formulation avoids a false universal claim.

MCQ 17

Praptasya praptih means

A. attainment of what is already attained B. production of a new immortal body C. merger of two real substances D. ritual accumulation of merit

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Advaita liberation removes mistaken non-possession rather than producing Brahman.

MCQ 18

Prarabdha karma explains

A. why Brahman creates B. why the liberated knower's body may continue after knowledge C. why Maya is eternal D. why Madhva accepts five differences

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The released-arrow analogy explains continued embodiment without renewed bondage.

MCQ 19

Which school makes taratamya among liberated souls a distinctive doctrine?

A. Advaita B. Visistadvaita C. Dvaita D. Suddhadvaita

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Madhva preserves real jiva-jiva difference and gradation even in moksha.

MCQ 20

Strict Advaitic jivanmukti is not central to Ramanuja because

A. he rejects liberation B. he denies consciousness C. he accepts only ritual action D. liberation is perfected real relation, not merely sublation of individuality while embodied

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Visistadvaita preserves the real self-God relation and does not treat embodiment as a merely apparent limitation removed by identity-knowledge.

MCQ 21

Aprthaksiddhi means

A. inseparable existence of a real qualifier or mode in relation to its substance B. absolute identity without qualification C. independent plurality D. illusory superimposition

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Ramanuja uses it to hold real cit and acit within one qualified Brahman.

MCQ 22

Which pair correctly states two of Madhva's five differences?

A. Maya-Brahman and avidya-jiva B. jiva-jiva and jada-jada C. saksi-Isvara and Maya-avidya D. nirguna-saguna and sat-asat

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The five include differences among souls and among material things, not only God-world difference.

MCQ 23

Nimbarka's standard threefold classification of acit is

A. sat, cit, ananda B. Maya, avidya, adhyasa C. prakrta, aprakrta and kala D. body, mind and senses

Correct answer: C

Explanation: This classification places empirical matter, non-prakritic divine substance and time within dependent real acit.

MCQ 24

Acintyabhedhabheda holds that difference and non-difference are

A. both illusory B. merely linguistic C. successive stages abolished in moksha D. jointly real but inconceivable in their full relation

Correct answer: D

Explanation: The Caitanya tradition preserves both poles without reducing one to the other.

MCQ 25

Remedial focus: Which statement corrects the trap 'nirguna means blank nothingness'?

A. Nirguna denies limiting empirical predicates while sat-cit-ananda expresses Brahman's intrinsic nature B. Nirguna means Brahman has no reality C. Nirguna is identical with Maya D. Nirguna is Madhva's name for Visnu

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Advaita's apophatic language removes limitation, not being, consciousness or bliss.

MCQ 26

Remedial focus: Why is aprthaksiddhi not identity?

A. Because cit and acit are unreal B. Because the real mode is distinct yet cannot exist independently of Brahman C. Because Brahman is one item among many D. Because relation disappears in devotion

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Inseparability preserves difference within dependence.

MCQ 27

Remedial focus: Which answer correctly handles the 2018 printed claim that Maya is needed by Ramanuja?

A. Claim Ramanuja accepts Sankara's Maya unchanged B. Ignore the printed line C. Flag the anomaly and explain that Ramanuja instead needs a real account of plurality through cit, acit and aprthaksiddhi D. Say both deny the world

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The safe answer preserves the paper wording without falsifying Ramanuja's doctrine.

MCQ 28

Remedial focus: Which item is often wrongly omitted from pancavidhabheda?

A. God-soul difference B. soul-matter difference C. God-matter difference D. matter-matter difference

Correct answer: D

Explanation: UPSC answers frequently stop at theological difference and omit internal plurality of material things.

MCQ 29

Remedial focus: What does bhaga-tyaga-laksana discard in tat tvam asi?

A. Incompatible empirical adjuncts while retaining pure consciousness B. Both words and all meaning C. Only the meaning of tat D. The authority of scripture

Correct answer: A

Explanation: It abandons lordship/finitude conditions, not the common consciousness essence.

MCQ 30

Remedial focus: Why is shell-silver not *asat* for Advaita?

A. Because it exists eternally B. Because it is presented in experience even though later sublated C. Because Nyaya calls it real D. Because it is Brahman

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Never-present entities such as a hare's horn are *asat*; illusion is phenomenally presented.

MCQ 31

Remedial focus: Which statement best qualifies 'vivarta develops *parinama*'?

A. They are identical theories B. Vivarta accepts real change more strongly C. Vivarta retains causal dependence but rejects real transformation under the premise of changeless Brahman D. Vivarta is Nyaya atomism

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The continuity lies in dependence; the rupture lies in denying modification.

MCQ 32

Remedial focus: What is the correct relation between *adhyasa* and *anirvacaniya-khyati*?

A. They are rival Vedanta schools B. *Adhyasa* is liberation; *khyati* is bondage C. They are exact synonyms with no distinction D. *Adhyasa* is the superimposing process; *khyati* theory explains the erroneous object's status

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Connecting but not conflating the two produces a precise Advaita answer.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

The models follow directive fidelity and the pattern **claim -> named evidence/example -> analysis -> qualification**.

Original 10-mark Question 1

Question: Distinguish the epistemic role of *sruti* in Advaita from its role in Visistadvaita. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Advaita and Visistadvaita both treat *sruti* as authoritative, but the metaphysics it reveals and its relation to other *pramanas* differ.

For Advaita, perception and inference operate within knower-known duality and cannot objectify nirguna Brahman. Mahavakyas such as **tat tvam asi** reveal the self as non-dual consciousness through bhaga-tyaga-laksana. *Sruti* functions like a clearing instrument: it removes *avidya* and is itself transcended when the *pramana-prameya* structure is sublated.

For Ramanuja, *sruti* reveals a qualified personal Brahman with infinite auspicious qualities. His principle that all cognition is of the qualified means scriptural negations remove defects, not every predicate. Texts on creation, indwelling control and devotion disclose real *cit* and *acit* as Brahman's body. *Sruti* therefore confirms, rather than finally dissolves, a real relation among God, self and world.

Thus Advaita gives *sruti* a unique self-cancelling role in revealing non-objective identity; Visistadvaita gives it an enduring realist-theistic role in revealing qualified unity.

Why this earns marks: It compares function, content and final status of scripture, and uses mahavakya semantics and the body-soul model as evidence.

Original 10-mark Question 2

Question: Why is the distinction between mithya and tuccha indispensable to Advaita? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

The distinction prevents Advaita from collapsing into nihilism. **Tuccha** is sheer impossibility, like a hare's horn: it is never presented. **Mithya** is experienced and causally effective but sublatale, like shell-silver or rope-snake.

Jagat must be mithya because ordinary action, ethics, karma and scripture function within it. Calling it tuccha would make error and correction equally impossible. Yet the world cannot be paramarthically real because Brahman-knowledge sublates independent plurality. **Badha** therefore places the world at the vyavaharika level, between never-sublated Brahman and merely illusory pratibhasika objects.

The distinction also supports vivartavada: appearance depends on a real substrate without changing it. Ramanuja objects that this middle status is verbally unstable; Advaita replies that the classification concerns grades of sublatability, not a third bare value between being and non-being.

Hence mithya preserves empirical validity while denying ultimacy; tuccha would erase experience altogether.

Why this earns marks: It defines both terms, uses two canonical examples, links the distinction to levels of reality and states the realist objection.

Original 15-mark Question 1

Question: Critically examine whether Ramanuja's aprthaksiddhi successfully mediates between Advaita identity and Dvaita difference. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Aprthaksiddhi is Ramanuja's doctrine that cit and acit are real, distinct modes that cannot exist independently of Brahman. It aims to preserve non-duality without treating plurality as illusion.

Against Advaita, it protects real selfhood, world, causation and devotion. The **sarira-sariri** model supplies evidence: a body is supported, controlled and purposive in relation to its indwelling self. Similarly, the universe is internal to Narayana without being numerically identical. This makes scriptural descriptions and bhakti ultimately meaningful.

Against Dvaita, aprthaksiddhi prevents plurality from becoming a set of substances externally related to God. Nothing exists outside the one qualified whole. Dependence is constitutive rather than merely causal.

Two objections remain. Sankara can argue that real changing modes compromise Brahman's immutability. Madhva can argue that inseparability does not establish non-duality; real difference remains difference. Ramanuja replies that qualifications express divine plenitude, not limitation, and that the controller is not reduced to every defect of the controlled body.

Aprthaksiddhi therefore mediates successfully if an absolute may possess real internal differentiation. It does not refute rival first principles, but it offers a coherent third model: neither identity without plurality nor plurality outside unity.

Why this earns marks: It tests the doctrine against both neighbouring schools, uses the three marks of bodyhood, and gives a conditional verdict tied to the central presupposition.

Original 15-mark Question 2

Question: Compare the soteriological implications of pratibimbavada and pancavidhabheda. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Pratibimbavada and pancavidhabheda explain liberation in opposite ways because one treats individuality as reflected appearance while the other treats difference as eternal reality.

In Advaita reflection theory, Brahman-consciousness is the **bimba**; jiva is its reflection in avidya, while Isvara is reflection in Maya. Like a face unaffected by a distorted mirror, original consciousness remains pure. Moksha occurs when knowledge removes identification with the limited reflection. It is **praptasya praptih**, not travel or merger, and supports jivanmukti.

Madhva's five differences—God-soul, soul-soul, soul-matter, God-matter and matter-matter—cannot be sublated. Correct knowledge reveals dependence on Visnu and the falsity of identity claims. Moksa is grace-enabled eternal service, with real selfhood and possible **taratamya** among liberated souls.

Pratibimbavada explains freedom as de-identification and secures metaphysical unity, but critics say it makes personhood and devotion provisional. Pancavidhabheda secures permanent relationship and realism, but accepts ultimate plurality and hierarchy.

Thus their soteriological contrast is recognition of original identity versus fulfilment of eternal difference. Each transforms its ontology directly into a theory of liberation.

Why this earns marks: It covers mechanism, means, final state and criticism for both doctrines, using bimba, praptasya praptih, five differences and taratamya as named evidence.

Original 20-mark Question 1

Question: Does Advaita solve the one-many problem, or merely relocate it into Maya? Discuss with reference to Ramanuja and Madhva. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Advaita solves the one-many problem by distinguishing levels of reality: changeless Brahman alone is ultimate, while plurality arises through Maya as vivarta. Whether this is a solution or relocation depends on the coherence of Maya.

The positive achievement is substantial. Rope-snake shows how a many-formed appearance can depend on a substrate without modifying it. **Adhyasa** explains empirical identity by mutual superimposition, while avaccheda and reflection models explain many jivas without partitioning consciousness. The three levels of reality preserve ordinary causality and ethics without granting them ultimacy.

Ramanuja argues that the explanatory burden reappears in Maya. The **sapta-anupapatti** asks for its locus, power of concealment, nature, proof, remover and cessation. The asraya dilemma is acute: Brahman as locus risks impurity; jiva as locus presupposes what avidya must explain. Ramanuja replaces Maya with real cit and acit internally related to Brahman through aprthaksiddhi. His model explains plurality directly but must show that changing modes do not compromise the absolute.

Madhva's criticism is more radical. **Pancavidhabheda** makes difference irreducible and argues that cognition, devotion and moral agency presuppose a real knower-known distinction. This avoids Maya's third ontological grade but turns ultimate reality into an ordered plurality under Visnu.

Advaita replies that neither qualified nor dualist realism protects Brahman's immutability and non-duality. Maya is not a second substance; it names experienced but sublatale appearance. The reply works if badha legitimately grades reality. If that criterion is rejected, "anirvacaniya" can look like a label for the unsolved relation.

My verdict is graded. Advaita gives the most economical account of unity and the most powerful soteriology of de-identification. It does not simply ignore plurality. Yet its solution is conditional on a contested level-ontology and leaves the locus of avidya under pressure. Ramanuja and Madhva remove that pressure only by accepting real differentiation at different strengths.

Why this earns marks: It states Advaita's constructive mechanism, tests the seven-objection and five-difference alternatives, gives replies and judges the precise condition under which the solution succeeds.

Original 20-mark Question 2

Question: Evaluate the claim that every Vedanta theory of moksa is a compressed expression of its metaphysics. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The claim is largely correct: each Vedanta school carries its account of Brahman, self and world into the means and final state of liberation.

In Advaita, atman is Brahman and bondage is adhyasa. Therefore moksa cannot be a produced event; it is **praptasya praptih** through mahavakya-knowledge. The necklace and rope-snake examples show recognition and sublation, while prarabdha explains jivanmukti. This is non-dual metaphysics in soteriological form.

In Visistadvaita, the self is a real atomic mode of Narayana through aprthaksiddhi. Liberation preserves individuality, so bhakti and prapatti culminate in communion and service. The body-soul model makes dependence perfected rather than abolished.

In Dvaita, pancavidhabheda is eternal. Right knowledge is knowledge of difference and dependence, while grace leads to eternal service. Taratamya among liberated souls follows from real jiva-jiva difference.

Nimbarka's dvaitadvaita yields communion without erasing simultaneous difference and dependence. Vallabha's Suddhadvaita, which treats the world as real manifestation, makes grace restore participation in Krsna's bliss rather than cancel world-appearance. Acintyabhedabheda makes loving relation itself ultimate because difference and non-difference are jointly real.

Practice alone cannot explain these variations: the schools may all use devotion, grace and knowledge, but those terms perform different tasks. Nor is metaphysics sufficient without religious discipline; ethical purification and devotion shape the subject capable of liberation.

Thus moksa is a compressed metaphysics, but not a merely deductive appendix. It is metaphysics translated into existential method: identity yields recognition, qualification yields communion, and difference yields service.

Why this earns marks: It covers the standard and wider schools, links ontology to means and final state, qualifies the thesis, and ends with a comparative formula.